

AUTOMATION FEASIBILITY RESEARCH PLAN

ALLIES CONNECT - GROUP 4

Purpose

This document outlines the research approach and evaluation methods that will be used by the development team to identify, validate, and outline potential automation features for the Allies Connect Phase II project.

Goals

There are many goals tied to this research effort, but ultimately it is to provide a validated and prioritized list of recommended features that should be implemented into future development phases of Allies Connect. To achieve this, the development team will complete various subgoals. The team will identify any repetitive processes or workflows within the system that may be suitable for automation. They will conduct web-based research to find any automation features that are currently being used in similar systems. The team will consider approaches to allow for automated data ingestion. The features that these approaches produce will then be evaluated to determine the anticipated feasibility, benefits, risk, development time and effort, and cost. These parameters will then be used to create a scoring matrix to organize these recommendations from best to worst.

Scope

This research will identify and evaluate automation features relating to resource listing updates, resource availability verification, volunteer reminder and scheduling, calendar data ingestion relating to calendars and events, data classification, and outdated listing detection.

Methodology

The team will use various methods to evaluate the proposed automated features. As previously mentioned, one of the goals of this research plan is to identify how existing platforms utilize automation for their system. For each of these platforms, the team will document and analyze how automated features are used, data ingestion is performed, and automation and user control is balanced to maximize system performance. Additionally, the team will analyze how current

nonprofit and community outreach programs publish events and create and update resources to identify a standardized structure to allow for easy automation implementation.

Evaluation Criteria

A set of evaluation criteria will be used to determine the best options for potential automation features. Each of these criteria will be rated 1 through 5, 1 being the worst and 5 being the best. The scores will then be combined to determine the total score. The total score will then be used to aid in the process of deciding which automated features to pursue. The first is feasibility, which refers to the features compatibility with the systems design and architecture. The more changes that need to be made to the system to adapt the feature, the worse the score. Cost is another very important aspect to consider. Maintenance and monitoring needs, architecture requirements, and free software and hardware package options all drive the cost of the implementation. The benefits of implementing an automated feature for the user is a valuable characteristic to measure. Some benefits may include increased data accuracy, reduced workload for administrators or providers, and improved user usability. There are also risks that need to be considered when introducing new features. Depending on the type of feature, data accuracy could be hindered, unnecessary dependencies may be added to the system, and privacy concerns may enter the realm of possibilities. Finally, the implementation and development efforts must be understood to ensure the feature can be created, tested, and supported in a realistic and beneficial time frame. Below shows an example of the scoring matrix that will be used when evaluating candidate features:

Feature Name Scoring Matrix

Criterion	Score (1-5)
Feasibility	4
Cost	3
User Benefit	5
Risk	2
Implementation Effort	1

Feature Name Score = $4 + 3 + 5 + 2 + 1 = 15$

Validation Process

Each automation feature will go through an initial screening to make sure that they are aligned with the project constraints. The team will test the technical feasibility of the features that pass the initial screening to help identify challenges before moving forward. Shortlisted features will be presented to the sponsor for feedback. The features that do not align with Allies Connect's

needs will be removed and the remaining features will be scored based on the evaluation criteria.

Feature Selection

The automation features will be selected based on their total criteria scores, priority categories, and overall feedback and input from the project sponsors. There will be four priority categories: Must Have, Should Have, Nice to Have, and Not Recommended. Must Have features score high in all criteria, offer significant benefit, have low risk, and have low cost. Should Have features score well but have a couple of drawbacks. Nice to Have features have some value but also challenges that make them need to be considered for phases beyond Phase II. Not Recommended features have low scores because of high risk, high cost, and minimal benefit.

Deliverables

The deliverables of this research plan are the Automation Feasibility Report and the Future Automation Roadmap. In the report, the team will document how current nonprofits publish events and resources, complete a comparative analysis of existing platforms, and create a feature evaluation matrix. The report will help with creating the Future Automation Roadmap.

Success Criteria

The research effort is successful if:

- At least 5 feasible automation features are recommended by priority
- A complete and justified feature evaluation matrix is created
- The roadmap includes:
 - Prioritized features list
 - Recommended technical approach
 - Identified risks and mitigation
 - Suggested pilot partners for Phase II testing
- The sponsor approves the final roadmap
- Research deliverables meet timeline and quality expectations

Change Record

Apr 12, 2026